

A Hospital Closed. Now a Brother Wonders If His Sister Could Have Been Saved.

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What if the nearest emergency room was 20 miles away and you were having a heart attack? That's the reality for people in Martin County, North Carolina, after their only hospital closed in 2023. Debra Pierce's brother, Stanley Sears, died of a heart attack a year later. Emergency crews worked on him for half an hour but couldn't **revive** him for the long drive to the next hospital.

'We'll never know if he could have been saved that night,' Pierce said, holding back tears. She still scrolls through photos of her brother on her phone, remembering his smile.

The hospital shut down suddenly, surprising even local leaders. The company running it filed for **bankruptcy** without warning. Now, the county is spending millions just to keep the empty building maintained, hoping to reopen it someday.

There's a \$50 billion national fund meant to help **rural** healthcare, and North Carolina is set to get \$213 million of it. But here's the catch: the money can only go to hospitals that are already open. Martin County's hospital is closed, so it won't get a penny. The **county manager** says the fund 'is not going to help us get this place reopened.'

Instead, the county plans to spend \$1.5 million on two advanced **paramedic** units with special **lifesaving equipment**. Pierce prays that will help. 'There's some answered prayers happening every day,' she says. But for her brother, it's too late.

Word Treasure

paramedic -- A specially trained person who gives medical help in emergencies, often in an ambulance.

bankruptcy -- When a company runs out of money and legally says it cannot pay its bills, often leading to closure.

rural -- In the countryside, far from big cities and often with fewer services.

county manager -- The person in charge of running a county's business and services.

lifesaving equipment -- Special machines and tools that can help keep a very sick person alive.

revive -- To bring someone back to life or consciousness after their heart has stopped.

Background you need

In recent years, over 100 rural hospitals across the United States have closed because they couldn't afford to stay open, leaving many communities without nearby emergency care.

North Carolina has been hit hard, especially in farming areas like Martin County where people often have to drive long distances to see a doctor.

The \$50 billion fund mentioned is part of a larger government plan to help struggling hospitals, but the rules often prevent closed ones from getting money to reopen.

Break it down

WHO: Debra Pierce and her brother Stanley Sears, residents of Martin County

WHAT: The only hospital closed, and her brother died of a heart attack; the county can't get federal money to reopen it

WHERE: Martin County, North Carolina, a rural area

WHY: The hospital owner filed for bankruptcy without warning, and the federal fund rules only help hospitals that are already open

Why it matters

When a hospital closes, it's not just a building that disappears -- it's a lifeline for families, and this story shows how unfair rules can put people in danger just because of where they live.

Test what you remember

1. What happened to the only hospital in Martin County?
 - (A) It got much bigger
 - (B) It closed suddenly in 2023
 - (C) It moved to a nearby town
 - (D) It was given a new name
2. Who died of a heart attack a year after the hospital closed?
 - (A) Debra Pierce
 - (B) Stanley Sears
 - (C) A county paramedic
 - (D) The county manager
3. Why can't Martin County's closed hospital get money from the \$50 billion national fund?
 - (A) The fund has already run out
 - (B) The hospital was too small to qualify
 - (C) The money only goes to hospitals that are already open
 - (D) The county did not apply in time
4. About how far is the nearest emergency room from Martin County?
 - (A) 5 miles
 - (B) 20 miles
 - (C) 50 miles
 - (D) 100 miles
5. What is the county planning to spend \$1.5 million on?
 - (A) Building a brand?new hospital
 - (B) Two advanced paramedic units with lifesaving equipment
 - (C) A medical helicopter for emergencies
 - (D) A memorial statue for Stanley Sears
6. How does Debra Pierce feel about the situation?
 - (A) She is angry and wants to move away
 - (B) She thinks the hospital should have never been built
 - (C) She prays the new paramedic units will help and sees some prayers being answered
 - (D) She believes her brother could have been saved no matter what

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Grieving family member:** We lost Stanley because help was too far. The system failed us, and we worry others will suffer the same way.
2. **County official:** The federal rules make no sense -- we have a building, we have a need, but we can't get money because the door is locked. We're trying to find other solutions.
3. **Policy analyst:** This situation shows that the current aid system needs to change. If we don't help closed hospitals reopen, whole communities are left without emergency care, which costs lives.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):